

Bales Interaction Process Analysis (IPA)

The IPA method of analyzing sentiment is to identify and then record each instance of a group interaction based on the **nature** of the ongoing small group interaction. It is not used to measure the content of this interaction. (Bales)

Bales IPA is based on scoring interactions based on 'units' of interaction or communication, these scores are applied to a predetermined set of categories, and an analysis made based on the scores of each category. These units are typically made up from one simple sentence expressing one idea. Complex sentences expressing more than one idea are scored based on the number of independent clauses they may contain.

Fragments of sentences can be scored as communication, one 'point' each, but the problem with these comes from the interpretation of them. For instance, a statement of "What?" can range from simply seeking clarification to an expression of disbelief. These fragment sentences must then be taken in context in order to be categorized.

In cases of oral or physical studies, simple sounds like grunts or sighs can typically be categorized and even facial expressions if the observer feels they convey enough meaning to be categorized. (Bales)

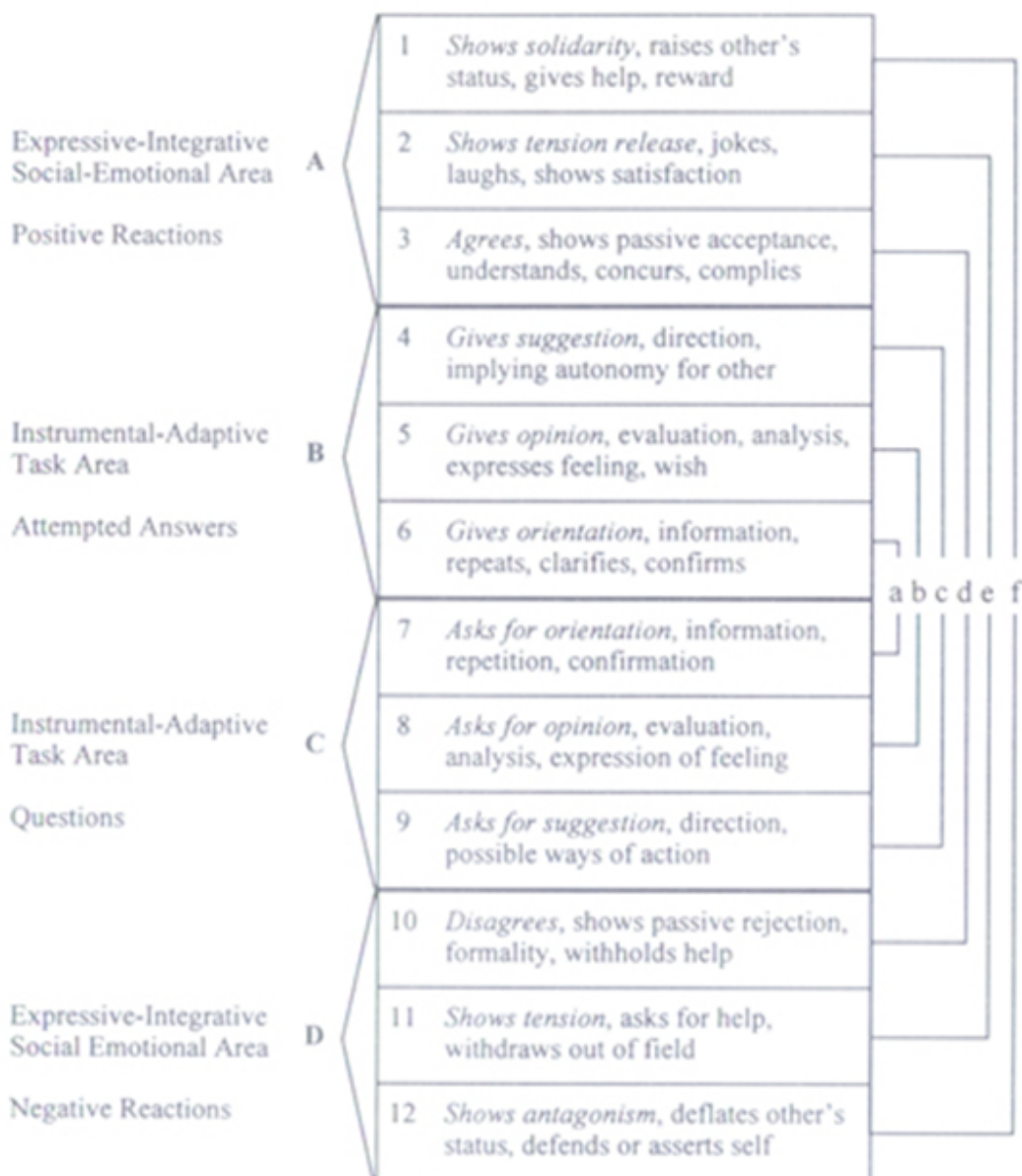


Figure 1.3 Bales IPA chart.

For a further explanation of the Bales IPA chart, please click on the following link to launch a video tutorial.

[http://relayfiles.njit.edu/da225/NJIT_Default/Flash%20\(Medium\)/Bales_Tutorial_Flash_\(Medium\)_](http://relayfiles.njit.edu/da225/NJIT_Default/Flash%20(Medium)/Bales_Tutorial_Flash_(Medium)_)

Key:

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|-----------------------|-----------------------------------|
| A. Positive reactions | a. Problems of orientation |
| B. Attempted answers | b. Problems of evaluation |
| C. Questions | c. Problems of control |
| D. Negative Answers | d. Problems of decision |
| | e. Problems of tension-management |
| | f. Problems of integration |